

COURSE & SYLLABUS / FALL SEMESTER

ART LAB: FOUNDATIONS

SEEING, MAKING & MEANING

A mixed-media fine arts course built around observation, experimentation, and a deeper understanding of materials and process.

THE SEMESTER IN SIXTEEN PIGMENTS

One pigment for every week of the course



**A FINE ARTS
COURSE,
TAUGHT LIVE
ONLINE**

WEEKLY CLASS

About one hour, live, with a short demo video before each session

BETWEEN CLASSES

Project work and 5–10 minute sketchbook practice most days

FOR

High school students; motivated middle schoolers welcome

WELCOME

AN ART CLASS THAT BEGINS WITH SEEING

Fine arts taught through making, experimentation, and an understanding of how materials work.

ABOUT THE COURSE

Art Lab: Foundations is a mixed-media fine arts course built around observation, experimentation, and a deeper understanding of materials and process. Students learn to see carefully, draw with confidence, and make choices that give their work meaning.

The semester begins with drawing, observation, color, and visual thinking. As students build confidence, the course expands into handmade paint, mixed media, layered surfaces, and selected sculptural and cementitious processes. Along the way, students learn how artists across history have used materials, from egg tempera and gold leaf to plaster and print, to shape what their work communicates. Materials are one of the ways students learn to think and work like artists, not the entire subject of the course.

The course closes with a more self-directed final project, planned, tested and refined over a full month.

YOUR STUDENT WILL

-  Draw from observation with structure, proportion and depth
-  Transform observation into imagination through Surrealism
-  Build layered mixed-media compositions
-  Work with gold leaf, light and experimental printmaking
-  Use light, value and composition to guide the viewer's eye
-  Mix color by hand and paint with egg tempera and casein
-  Cast, carve and finish a sculptural relief
-  Plan, refine and present a self-directed final project

AT A GLANCE

LENGTH	16 weeks, fall semester	LIVE CLASS	About one hour each week, online
BEFORE CLASS	Short demo video and setup checklist	SKETCHBOOK	5–10 minutes, 4–6 days a week
BETWEEN CLASSES	Project work, drying and curing time	EXPERIENCE	None needed; curiosity matters most

PROCESS OVER PERFECTION. STUDIES, FAILED TESTS AND REVISIONS ARE PART OF THE COURSE, NOT EVIDENCE THAT SOMETHING WENT WRONG.

WHAT STUDENTS GAIN

SKILL AND JUDGMENT, BUILT TOGETHER

STUDIO SKILLS

Drawing, composition, proportion, light, value, shading, color, craftsmanship and visual judgment.

CREATIVE EXPLORATION

Mixed media, experimentation, transformation, problem-solving, imagination and developing individual ideas.

MATERIALS + PROCESS

Pigments and binders, surfaces, handmade paint, historical techniques, and selected sculptural and cementitious materials.

Art history runs through all three as a thread: every week connects to artists and ideas from earlier or later in the semester, and to the course theme of seeing, making and meaning.

THE SEMESTER ARC

Phase I OBSERVE

OBSERVATION

Break complex subjects into large shapes and simple three-dimensional forms before adding detail.

MIXED MEDIA

Combine drawing, paint, collage, found material and print as one language, not separate subjects.

Phase II EXPLORE

DRAWING

Use proportion, overlap, perspective, value, edge, texture and cast shadow to create believable form.

MATERIAL THINKING

Build, cast, carve, sand, stain and gild, considering what the physical material contributes.

Phase III TRANSFORM

COLOR

Mix primaries intentionally; understand warm and cool, complements, limited palettes and value shifts.

ART HISTORY + MEANING

Use historical and contemporary art to discuss culture, faith, beauty, symbolism and memory.

Phase IV REFINE

Phase V PRESENT

QUESTIONS WE RETURN TO

What changes when we slow down and truly observe before drawing?

How do form, value, color, texture and composition guide what a viewer notices?

What is paint actually made of, and how does a binder change the behavior of pigment?

How can flat images become layered surfaces, reliefs and physical objects?

How have artists used beauty, disruption, symbolism, light and material to communicate belief or meaning?

How does an artist move from an assigned technique toward intentional personal choices?

HOW A WEEK WORKS

AN ONLINE STUDIO THAT FEELS LIKE A STUDIO

Demonstrations move to short videos before class, so the live hour is spent looking together and making, with the instructor troubleshooting in real time.

BEFORE CLASS

Watch a 6–8 minute demo video filmed from overhead.

Set out the week's materials using the setup checklist, so class time goes to making.

LIVE CLASS, ~60 MIN

LOOK

LEARN

MAKE

CLOSE

5–10 min Slow looking at one artwork: what do you see, think, wonder?

10–15 min Technique, material science, artists and history.

25–35 min Studio time with live help and feedback.

5 min What happens next, and what to notice while working.

BETWEEN CLASSES

Continue the project; allow drying and curing time.

Sketchbook practice most days.

Post a photo to the class gallery with one “I notice...” comment on a classmate’s work.

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

5–10 MIN

4–6 days
a week,
every
week of
the
course

Short, frequent drawing keeps the observation skills from the first weeks growing all semester, even in weeks spent with paint and plaster. Each week has its own prompt, tied to what the class is learning.

The sketchbook also holds thumbnails, color recipes, pigment tests, material notes and mistakes worth remembering. It can be messy. It is evidence of thinking.

EXAMPLE PROMPT, WEEK 11

Draw a shiny object, like a spoon, and map its reflections as shapes.

THE BOOKEND DRAWING

In Week 1 students draw an ordinary object. Before the final class they draw it again with the same setup. Side by side, the two drawings show a semester of growth more clearly than any grade.



WEEK 01



WEEK 16

CRITIQUE, ONLINE

Each week three students are spotlighted live, and everyone shares in the class gallery. We begin with observation before interpretation, and ask questions before suggesting fixes. The aim is specific, useful feedback, never competition.

COURSE ARC

FIVE PHASES, ONE SEMESTER

The semester begins with drawing and visual thinking, then builds toward color, mixed media, sculptural material and a self-directed final project.

Phase I



DRAWING FOUNDATIONS

3 WEEKS Weeks 1–3

Students learn to see, simplify, construct and light form: basic shapes, proportion, depth, value, composition and simple figure construction. Then they use those skills to transform observation into imagination through Surrealism.

Looking outside class: Light hunt. Photograph three strong cast shadows at home and bring the best one to class.

Phase II



COLOR + PAINT

2 WEEKS Weeks 4–5

Color theory becomes physical. Students mix their own color from primaries, then make and paint with egg tempera and casein, learning how pigment becomes paint.

Looking outside class: Zoom in. Study one tempera painting up close in a museum or on Google Arts & Culture, and sketch a single detail.

Phase III



MIXED MEDIA + SURFACE

3 WEEKS Weeks 6–8

Drawing, paint, collage and found imagery combine into layered compositions, then rise off the page into a shallow relief that holds real light and shadow.

Looking outside class: Relief in the wild. Find carved or cast relief in your town, on a doorway, building, monument or grave marker, and photograph it in low, raking light.

Phase IV



FORM, LIGHT + PROCESS

4 WEEKS Weeks 9–12

Selected sculptural materials, gold leaf and printmaking show how material and process shape what a work communicates.

Looking outside class: Light on a surface. Find one gilded, metallic or reflective surface and photograph it in two different lights.

Phase V



FINAL PROJECT

4 WEEKS Weeks 13–16

A month of self-directed work: students plan, test, build and refine one project, choosing the processes that best serve their own idea.

Looking outside class: See one show. Visit a museum, gallery or student exhibition in person before the final critique.

AT A GLANCE

SIXTEEN WEEKS

PHASE I DRAWING FOUNDATIONS

Week 01		See, simplify + construct	DRAWING FOUNDATIONS I	Forms, proportion, depth and gesture
Week 02		Light, value + composition	DRAWING FOUNDATIONS II	Light source, value, shading and composition
Week 03		Transform: Surrealism	DRAWING FOUNDATIONS III	From observation to imagination

PHASE II COLOR + PAINT

Week 04		Mixing what you see	COLOR THEORY + EGG TEMPERA	Mix color by hand; make and use egg tempera
Week 05		Paint is made	PIGMENT + CASEIN PAINT	Pigment + binder: make casein paint

PHASE III MIXED MEDIA + SURFACE

Week 06		Layer + transform	MIXED MEDIA I	Alter, combine, obscure, reveal
Week 07		Composition	MIXED MEDIA II	Collage, scale, transparency, focal point
Week 08		When the surface becomes an object	TEXTURE + RELIEF	From flat image to tactile surface

PHASE IV FORM, LIGHT + PROCESS

Week 09		Design + cast	SCULPTURAL MATERIALS I	Design a mold, mix and cast
Week 10		Carve + finish	SCULPTURAL MATERIALS II	Demold, carve, finish and combine
Week 11		Gilding and reflection	SURFACE + LIGHT	Gold leaf, reflective and translucent surface
Week 12		Chance and control	CHANCE + EXPERIMENTAL PROCESS	Printmaking: transfer, monoprint, cyanotype

PHASE V FINAL PROJECT

Week 13		Concept + material plan	FINAL PROJECT I	Proposal, thumbnails, material tests
Week 14		Build	FINAL PROJECT II	Establish structure and major relationships
Week 15		Develop + refine	FINAL PROJECT III	Surface, color, editing, critique
Week 16		Finish + present	FINAL PROJECT IV	Resolve, photograph, present and reflect

TOTAL	16 weeks	16 live sessions of about one hour, plus sketchbook practice and project work between classes
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01

Week 01

DRAWING FOUNDATIONS I

PHASE I

SEE, SIMPLIFY + CONSTRUCT

Anything can be drawn once you see the simple forms underneath it.

THREAD Leonardo drew to understand. That habit of looking underlies every week that follows.

GRAPHITE

LOOK + DISCUSS

Leonardo's notebooks and Dürer's studies show drawing as a way of paying attention. Rembrandt's quick pen sketches show how to capture a pose in seconds.

IN CLASS

Sphere, box, cylinder and cone. Build complex objects from simple forms, check proportion by sighting, and use overlap and placement to create depth. Finish with 30-second gesture poses and a simple figure built from basic forms.

BETWEEN CLASSES

Two observational drawings built from big shapes to details, plus one page of gestures.

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

4-6 times a week, 5-10 minutes

Alternate days: one object built from simple forms, or five quick gestures of people around you.

ON THE TABLE Pencils HB-6B, eraser, sketchbook, a few household objects.

STRETCH Draw a chair or bicycle using only construction lines.

02

Week 02

DRAWING FOUNDATIONS II

PHASE I

LIGHT, VALUE + COMPOSITION

Light turns shape into form, and composition decides what the viewer sees first.

THREAD Caravaggio's light returns in Week 11, when light itself becomes a material.

BONE BLACK

LOOK + DISCUSS

Caravaggio and Rembrandt used light for drama and meaning. Edward Hopper used light and placement to create mood.

IN CLASS

One light source and a value scale. Form shadow and cast shadow; shading by blending, hatching and cross-hatching. Light a simple figure built from forms, then plan a value drawing through thumbnails exploring focal point, cropping and placement.

BETWEEN CLASSES

A finished value drawing with a clear focal point, planned through at least three thumbnails.

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

4-6 times a week, 5-10 minutes

One object in single-source light, drawn in three values inside a thumbnail frame.

ON THE TABLE Pencils, blending stump, desk lamp, a white object such as an egg or mug.

STRETCH A value drawing in charcoal and white chalk on toned paper.

03

Week 03

DRAWING FOUNDATIONS III

PHASE I

TRANSFORM: SURREALISM

A strange image becomes powerful when it is drawn convincingly and says something true.

TWILIGHT BLUE

THREAD Surrealist chance methods return in Week 12.

LOOK + DISCUSS

Bosch's dream imagery, then Dalí, Magritte, Remedios Varo and Leonora Carrington. Distortion, juxtaposition, dream logic and metamorphosis as tools for asking deeper questions. Discussion: Beauty, Brokenness & Truth. Surrealism can be a visual language without being a worldview.

IN CLASS

Choose one transformation strategy: a scale shift, an impossible pairing, or one thing becoming another. Thumbnail it, then build it with believable form, light and shadow.

BETWEEN CLASSES

Complete the Surrealist drawing and write one sentence about the question it asks.

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

4–6 times a week, 5–10 minutes

One “what if” a day, drawn believably.

ON THE TABLE Drawing kit and reference photos.

STRETCH Include a figure built with the Week 1–2 construction method.

04

Week 04

COLOR THEORY + EGG TEMPERA

PHASE II

MIXING WHAT YOU SEE

Color theory becomes meaningful when you physically mix color instead of only naming it on a wheel.

EGG YOLK

THREAD Medieval tempera panels were often set against gold, which we revisit in Week 11.

LOOK + DISCUSS

Begin by reviewing the Surrealist drawings. Then the glowing panels of Duccio and Fra Angelico, and Andrew Wyeth's 20th-century tempera: why a slow, layered paint produces such luminous color.

IN CLASS

Primaries, secondaries, complements, warm and cool, value. Students mix pigment into egg-yolk binder and build their own color-mixing chart.

BETWEEN CLASSES

Finish the chart or a small tempera study using only colors you mixed. Optional: add selective color to the Surrealist drawing.

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

4–6 times a week, 5–10 minutes

Each day, note five colors you actually see (not their “name” color) and write how you would mix one.

ON THE TABLE Eggs, pigment pastes, palette, small brushes, watercolor paper or panel.

STRETCH Build form with hatched tempera strokes, the way medieval painters did.

05

Week 05

PIGMENT + CASEIN PAINT

PHASE II

PAINT IS MADE

Paint is pigment carried by a binder. Change the binder and you change the paint.

THREAD Jacob Lawrence's flat, bold shapes look ahead to collage in Weeks 6–7.

YELLOW OCHRE

LOOK + DISCUSS

Jacob Lawrence painted his Migration Series in casein tempera. We also look at milk paints in folk and decorative painting, and ask why an artist would choose a matte surface over a luminous one.

IN CLASS

A demonstration of how pigment becomes paint, and how milk becomes casein. Students mix pigment paste into prepared casein in small batches, compare it with egg tempera, and make a small painted study.

BETWEEN CLASSES

Finish the casein study. Note which colors covered well, which felt transparent, and how casein differed from tempera.

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

4–6 times a week, 5–10 minutes

Plan one scene from your day as flat shapes and a few colors, the way Lawrence composed.

ON THE TABLE Casein binder, pigment pastes, illustration board or cardboard, brushes.

STRETCH Use only three pigments plus white. How many colors can you mix?

06

Week 06

MIXED MEDIA I

PHASE III

LAYER + TRANSFORM

Adding material should change the image, not simply decorate it.

THREAD Schwitters's found scraps connect to Cornell's boxes and, later, to cast objects.

BURNT SIENNA

LOOK + DISCUSS

Kurt Schwitters, Joseph Cornell and Betye Saar, who brought ordinary materials into art. Can a material carry memory before it is altered?

IN CLASS

Combine a drawing or image with casein, collage paper, text, tracing paper, cardboard, thread, fabric or foil. Practice covering, revealing, tearing, cutting, sanding and redrawing.

BETWEEN CLASSES

Continue the layered piece, then remove at least one element that isn't helping. Editing is part of making.

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

4–6 times a week, 5–10 minutes

Tape in one found scrap a day (a ticket, a label, a leaf) and draw into or around it.

ON THE TABLE Glue, scissors, collage papers, found materials, casein paints.

STRETCH Build a layer you later sand back to reveal what lies beneath.

07

Week 07

MIXED MEDIA II

PHASE III

COMPOSITION

A mixed-media work needs the same compositional discipline as a drawing.

THREAD Höch's photomontage grew from the same era as the Surrealism of Week 3.

MADDER RED

LOOK + DISCUSS

Hannah Höch's photomontages and Romare Bearden's collages: fragments assembled into a new visual world. How context changes meaning.

IN CLASS

A new or expanded composition of found imagery, hand drawing and painted passages, focusing on scale change, overlap, negative space, focal point, transparency and edge.

BETWEEN CLASSES

Resolve the composition. Photograph it straight-on and write one note: where does the eye go first, and why?

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

4–6 times a week, 5–10 minutes

Three tiny thumbnails a day of the same subject, moving the focal point each time.

ON THE TABLE Printed images, tracing paper, glue, paints.

STRETCH Rebuild the same pieces into a second version with a new focal point.

08

Week 08

TEXTURE + RELIEF

PHASE III

WHEN THE SURFACE BECOMES AN OBJECT

The step from 2D to 3D can begin with only a few millimeters of depth.

THREAD Ghiberti's relief doors were cast in bronze and gilded, previewing Weeks 9–11.

RAW UMBER

LOOK + DISCUSS

Ghiberti's Gates of Paradise and Louise Nevelson's wall assemblages; relief in doors, architecture and sacred spaces. How real light changes a surface through the day.

IN CLASS

A shallow relief from cardboard, string, fabric, sand and modeling paste: raised and recessed areas, rough and smooth passages, edges that cast real shadows. Paint or stain only after the structure works.

BETWEEN CLASSES

Finish the relief and photograph a close-up in raking light. Collect small textures and objects to press into clay next week.

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

4–6 times a week, 5–10 minutes

Texture hunt: bark, brick, rope, fabric, any surface you could build.

ON THE TABLE Cardboard, glue, string, modeling paste, plasticine.

STRETCH Design with shadow: make the cast shadows part of the composition.

09

Week 09

SCULPTURAL MATERIALS I

PHASE IV

DESIGN + CAST

Casting reverses normal making: you design the empty space first and reveal the object later.

PLASTER WHITE

THREAD Rachel Whiteread casts empty space, the reverse of the Week 1 habit of seeing solid forms.

LOOK + DISCUSS

Roman concrete and the Pantheon, and Rachel Whiteread, who casts the empty space inside and around things. Why stone-like materials suggest permanence and memory.

IN CLASS

Safety briefing first. Press a design into oil-based clay inside a small container: incised lines, pressed textures, carved hollows. Mix casting plaster and pour. A cement mix is available to older students with instructor approval.

BETWEEN CLASSES

Let the cast set undisturbed. Sketch two finishing ideas for Week 10.

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

4–6 times a week, 5–10 minutes

Draw things in reverse: a footprint, the inside of a cup, a keyhole, a mold.

ON THE TABLE Plasticine, small container, pre-portioned plaster, mixing cup, gloves, goggles.

STRETCH Add integral pigment or fine aggregate to a test pour and compare.

10

Week 10

SCULPTURAL MATERIALS II

PHASE IV

CARVE + FINISH

A cast object is a beginning. Surface and context decide what it becomes.

GREEN EARTH

THREAD Kintsugi answers the Week 3 question: brokenness made beautiful.

LOOK + DISCUSS

Kintsugi, the Japanese art of mending broken pottery with gold, alongside ancient fragments and patina. Why artists keep cracks and wear instead of hiding them.

IN CLASS

Demold. Sand, carve, incise and refine edges; apply a pigment wash or stain. Begin joining the cast piece with wood, wire, paper, textile or a painted panel.

BETWEEN CLASSES

Complete the integrated object. Photograph the whole piece and one detail of its surface.

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

4–6 times a week, 5–10 minutes

Draw something cracked, worn or mended.

ON THE TABLE Carving tools, sandpaper, pigment wash, found materials.

STRETCH Break a test cast on purpose and design its repair.

11



GOLD LEAF

Week 11

SURFACE + LIGHT

PHASE IV

GILDING AND REFLECTION

Light can act like a material. A reflective surface changes as the viewer moves.

THREAD Gold grounds in icons and tempera panels close the loop from Week 4.

LOOK + DISCUSS

Byzantine and Ethiopian icons, illuminated manuscripts and Klimt, then kintsugi again. Gold used for luxury versus gold as a symbol: a field of light rather than a place.

IN CLASS

Simplified gilding with water-based size and imitation leaf, used as one intentional focal point, perhaps on the cast piece. Compare matte, glossy, translucent and metallic passages.

BETWEEN CLASSES

Finish the surface study and photograph it from two angles so the change in light is visible.

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

4–6 times a week, 5–10 minutes

Draw a shiny object (a spoon, a doorknob, a glass) and map its reflections as shapes.

ON THE TABLE Gilding size, imitation leaf, soft brush, cast piece or panel.

STRETCH Sgraffito: paint over gold, then scratch back through to it.

12



PRUSSIAN BLUE

Week 12

CHANCE + EXPERIMENTAL PROCESS

PHASE IV

CHANCE AND CONTROL

Not every decision has to be predicted. Artists can design a process, then respond to what happens.

THREAD Anna Atkins used cyanotype to observe plants, joining observation and art the way Week 1 joined observation and drawing.

LOOK + DISCUSS

Anna Atkins's cyanotypes, Degas's monotypes, Robert Rauschenberg's transfer drawings and Max Ernst's frottage, a Surrealist chance method that links back to Week 3.

BETWEEN CLASSES

Add one intentional intervention to the best print: drawing, cut, paint, text, stitch, gilding or collage. Bring it to Week 13 as a possible final-project test.

CHOOSE ONE PROCESS

Several fast experiments with one printmaking process, then select and alter the strongest rather than accepting the first result.

ACRYLIC TRANSFER

Move a laser-printed or photocopied image onto paper, panel or plaster with acrylic gel medium, then rub the paper away. Inkjet prints tend to smear.

MONOPRINT

Roll paint onto a gel plate, draw, mask and layer, and pull one-of-a-kind prints.

CYANOTYPE

Sun printing on pre-coated paper. A UV lamp helps on cloudy November days.

SUMINAGASHI

Floating-ink marbling: ink rings on water, lifted onto paper.

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

4–6 times a week, 5–10 minutes

Start each page with a chance mark (a rubbing, a blot, a drip) and turn it into something.

ON THE TABLE Gel medium, brayer, gel plate, sun-print paper, laser-printed images.

STRETCH Combine two processes: a transfer printed over a cyanotype.

13

Week 13

FINAL PROJECT I

PHASE V

CONCEPT + MATERIAL PLAN

Strong work starts with a question or intention, not a shopping list of techniques.

THREAD Name one artist from the semester whose thinking shapes your final project.

INDIGO

LOOK + DISCUSS

Artists who combine media because the material supports the idea, such as Joseph Cornell's boxes and Anselm Kiefer's paintings built with straw, lead and ash. Symbolism without forcing one fixed meaning.

IN CLASS

Develop 2–3 concepts in thumbnails and name the main visual problem. Choose at least two material families from the semester and make small tests. The instructor approves scope and materials.

BETWEEN CLASSES

Show the chosen concept, a rough composition, a material plan and at least one test sample.

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

4–6 times a week, 5–10 minutes

Daily idea pages: thumbnails, notes and reference sketches toward the final.

ON THE TABLE Anything from the semester's kits; the student's plan decides.

STRETCH A small, tightly connected series instead of a single piece.

14

Week 14

FINAL PROJECT II

PHASE V

BUILD

Establish the large relationships before polishing details.

THREAD Keep your chosen artist in view: what did they control, and what did they leave raw?

CAPUT MORTUUM

LOOK + DISCUSS

Michelangelo's unfinished Prisoners, where rough stone and refined form sit side by side. Craftsmanship is not the same as perfection: what must be controlled, and what can stay raw?

IN CLASS

Studio week. Build the support, main composition, relief, cast part or major painted areas. Feedback focuses on scale, structure, hierarchy and whether the materials are helping the idea.

BETWEEN CLASSES

Reach a clear midpoint. Photograph the work and name the single biggest problem to solve next.

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

4–6 times a week, 5–10 minutes

A daily study of one detail from your final project's subject.

ON THE TABLE Final-project materials.

STRETCH Make a small side study to test a risky decision before trying it on the main piece.

15

Week 15

FINAL PROJECT III

PHASE V

DEVELOP + REFINE

Refinement often means subtraction, repetition and better transitions, not adding more.

VIRIDIAN

THREAD Look back at your chosen artist: how did they know a work was finished?

LOOK + DISCUSS

Matisse photographed his Large Reclining Nude again and again as he simplified it over months. How do artists know when a work is resolved? Separating technical finishing from overworking.

IN CLASS

Continue surface, color, layering and assembly. Mid-project critique: what is strongest, what is competing, where does the eye go, what should go? Then revise.

BETWEEN CLASSES

Finish all major construction, leaving only finishing, photography and presentation. Make the bookend drawing before the final class.

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

4–6 times a week, 5–10 minutes

Draw your work in progress from a new angle each day and note one change.

ON THE TABLE Final-project materials.

STRETCH Write a 50-word museum-style label for your piece.

16

Week 16

FINAL PROJECT IV

PHASE V

FINISH + PRESENT

A work isn't finished until the artist can present it clearly and reflect on the decisions behind it.

ULTRAMARINE

THREAD Present your chosen artist alongside your work and explain the connection.

LOOK + DISCUSS

Back to the semester theme of seeing, making and meaning, with each student's Week 1 and bookend drawings side by side. Museum wall labels as a model for explaining a work in a few clear sentences.

IN CLASS

Final adjustments, photography in good light, then an online showcase. Each student answers three questions: What were you trying to do? Why these materials? What changed along the way?

BETWEEN CLASSES

A final sketchbook reflection: one skill gained, one material to explore further, one question still open.

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

4–6 times a week, 5–10 minutes

The bookend drawing, made before class: redraw your Week 1 subject with the same setup.

ON THE TABLE Finished work, a phone camera, good light.

STRETCH Assemble a one-page digital portfolio of your strongest work from the semester.

FINAL PROJECT / WEEKS 13–16

A SELF-DIRECTED FINAL PROJECT

CREATE ONE SUBSTANTIAL ARTWORK, OR A SMALL, TIGHTLY CONNECTED BODY OF WORK, THAT COMBINES AT LEAST TWO MATERIAL OR PROCESS FAMILIES FROM THE SEMESTER.

The materials should support the idea, not simply appear because they were used in class.

REQUIREMENTS

- | | |
|--|--|
| <p>01 A clear concept, question or visual intention that can be explained in ordinary language.</p> | <p>02 At least two material or process families from the semester, such as drawing + casein, collage + relief, cast plaster + gilding, or transfer + cyanotype.</p> |
| <p>03 Evidence of planning: thumbnails, reference images, a material test or a small prototype.</p> | <p>04 Meaningful development across Weeks 13–16. A one-night project doesn't meet the purpose of the assignment.</p> |
| <p>05 At least one revision after critique, and the ability to say what changed and why.</p> | <p>06 Clear documentation: a full image and a detail, photographed in even light against a simple background.</p> |
| <p>07 A short presentation describing intention, material choices, one problem solved and one unexpected discovery.</p> | <p>08 The bookend drawing, shown beside the student's Week 1 drawing.</p> |
| <p>09 One artist from the semester whose thinking shaped the project, named in the presentation.</p> | |

INTENTION

The student can explain the visual problem or idea being pursued.

MATERIAL

Materials are handled with growing control and chosen for a reason.

DEVELOPMENT

The work changes through testing, critique, editing and revision.

PRESENTATION

The finished work is documented and discussed clearly, even if the artist would keep refining it.

AT THE FINAL SHOWCASE,
EVERY STUDENT ANSWERS

WHAT WERE YOU TRYING TO DO?

WHY THESE MATERIALS?

WHAT CHANGED ALONG THE WAY?

A technically perfect object with no intentional choices is not automatically stronger than a rougher work with real investigation. Craft matters, but the course values observation, experimentation, judgment and thoughtful revision together.

STUDIO PRACTICE

SKETCHBOOK, CRITIQUE AND ASSESSMENT

THE ART LAB SKETCHBOOK

One sketchbook for the whole semester, used 4–6 days a week for 5–10 minutes of drawing.

Weekly prompts connect daily drawing to the week's material, so observation keeps growing.

It also holds thumbnails, proportion notes, value studies, color recipes and pigment tests.

Material observations and mistakes worth remembering belong here too.

Final-project planning and the closing reflection live in its last pages.

Pages can be messy. They are evidence of thinking, not portfolio pieces.

HOW WE TALK ABOUT WORK

"I notice..."

"This makes me think..."

Begin with observation before interpretation.

Be specific about visual evidence: edge, value, scale, color, texture, focal point, rhythm, material.

Ask questions before prescribing a fix. The goal is to help the artist see choices, not redesign the work.

Students may disagree about meaning. Good critique separates what is visible from what is interpreted.

SUGGESTED EVALUATION, IF A GRADE IS NEEDED

35%

PROCESS + ENGAGEMENT

Participation, preparation, sketchbook practice, tests, willingness to revise.

25%

STUDIO SKILL + CRAFT

Growing control of drawing, color, surface and materials.

25%

PROJECT DEVELOPMENT

Composition, problem-solving, experimentation, follow-through.

15%

FINAL + REFLECTION

Sustained development, material intention, presentation.

MATERIALS & SUPPLIES

SUPPLIES IN THREE STAGES

Supplies are staged so families aren't buying everything at once. Specialty items are selected, and where possible pre-portioned, by the instructor. A separate Materials Guide lists every item week by week.

WEEKS 1-3

DRAWING

Graphite pencils HB-6B, charcoal, kneaded eraser, blending stump, toned paper and the Art Lab sketchbook.

WEEKS 4-7

PAINT LAB

Pigment pastes, prepared casein binder, palette, brushes, panels and illustration board, collage papers and glue.

WEEKS 8-16

SURFACE + FORM

Modeling paste, plasticine, casting plaster, carving tools, sandpaper, gilding size and imitation leaf, gel medium, gel plate, brayer, sun-print paper, gloves and goggles.

FROM HOME Eggs, a few household objects, cardboard and found materials, a desk lamp, a phone for photos, and old kitchen utensils that can be retired to art use.

HOME STUDIO SAFETY

Safety takes priority over technical complexity. Every material week includes a short safety briefing.

Approved pigments only. Non-toxic, instructor-approved pigments. No lead, cadmium, cobalt or chromium.

No airborne dust. Casting powder comes pre-portioned. Never blow or dry-sweep; clean up with a damp cloth.

Plaster gets warm as it sets. Never cast hands or any part of the body.

Never pour plaster down a drain. Let leftovers harden in the cup, then throw them away.

Acrylic sheet, not glass, for transparent drawing activities.

Art utensils stay art utensils. Spoons and cups used for paint or plaster never return to the kitchen.

Pigment arrives as paste. Pre-dispersed in water, so there is no dry pigment dust at home.

Gloves and eye protection for casting, gilding size and any material the instructor identifies as irritating.

Cement mixes are caustic when wet. Optional for older students only, with gloves, goggles and an adult nearby.

No chemistry mixing at home. Cyanotype uses pre-coated paper. No caustic activators are used.

Supervised tools. Cutting tools, heat tools and wire only with age-appropriate supervision.

A wipeable work surface and old clothes or an apron for every material week.

ART LAB: FOUNDATIONS

**LEARN TO SEE
CAREFULLY.
UNDERSTAND HOW
MATERIALS BEHAVE.
MAKE WORK THAT
CARRIES AN IDEA.**

